



BOUNDLESS

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FROM THE DESK OF THE ACTING VICE-CHANCELLOR



Professor Marcus M Ramogale
Acting Vice-Chancellor
MUT

I am exhilarated to share with you that in one quarter, Mangosuthu University of Technology (MUT) is making inroads across the globe from a collaborative standpoint. Having signed an MoU with ESAIP Graduate School of Engineering in France and currently working on two more MoUs with France as well, we are on steroids with our internationalisation agenda. This is an investment of many more years to come. When we build international partnerships, we first focus

on outlook and sustainability, and these have been considered considerably. I am grateful to Dr Manyane Makua and to the delegation he led to France for the groundwork made so far, which they continue to navigate.

On 20 September, I was heartened by the opening speech of Professor Anders Hagfeldt, Vice Chancellor at Uppsala University, when he specifically welcomed MUT as a new member of the South Africa-Sweden Universities Forum (SASUF) which has a membership of 40 universities. In his welcome note, he reiterated the letter he had sent me, inviting me to join a delegation of 14 Swedish university presidents or vice-chancellors and university leaders together with Swedish funding agencies for a SASUF delegation trip for Vice-Chancellors to be hosted in Cape Town. This will coincide with the first SASUF physical research and innovation week in Cape Town, where MUT will be participants.

The high-quality research papers presented by MUT during the SASUF Goes Digital conference, held from 19 to 23 September, undoubtedly give me confidence of MUT's outstanding performance on a global stage. MUT as a member of SASUF, is now a participant in a network of 3 000 researchers participating in over 70 collaborative projects linked to the United Nations' Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) and Agenda 2030.

Our intentionality in the internationalisation agenda is also fuelled by the thirst for a comprehensive advancement of MUT. We are constantly exploring new and innovative ways which will take us to the next level, and we are succeeding. Doors that have previously seemed difficult to open, are suddenly being opened. Our people are active in various internationalisation projects and thus getting recognised internationally as you will read in this edition.

I am happy to announce that this year alone, we have signed more than 10 quality MoUs, and we continue to grow these because of the internationalisation agenda which is being implemented according to the MUT Strategy 2025. In the MUT Strategy 2030, the University will ensure that every academic and from middle management upwards, has an international partner. We can no longer keep on listening to ourselves. There is no greater time to spread our wings abroad than now.

Professor Marcus M Ramogale
Acting Vice-Chancellor

Our global destiny

is one where we see our students engaged in internationalised curricula and our staff and students experiencing international, intercultural communication and collaboration.

MUT TO HOST ITS 2ND INTERNATIONAL WEEK

We are pleased to present an outline of MUT's 2nd International Week (I-Week). It is scheduled to take place from 21 to 24 November. This hybrid event will make MUT a melting pot of different cultures, languages, and worlds.

The I-Week aims to ensure that every MUT employee and student learns from those already far ahead with internationalisation, understand the trajectories of internationalisation, and meet funders as well as major role-players in the internationalisation sector.

I-Week will host esteemed scholars, chief of parties, ambassadors, MUT research and academic partners, professionals in the international offices across academia, government, and multi-lateral funding agencies.

Highlights of the week will include:

- Lessons learnt from South Africa's Department of Higher Education and Training's Week in France,
- Understanding of South Africa's higher education landscape,
- Navigating partnership challenges,
- Ability to rise above negativity for collaborations to succeed,
- Strengthening KwaZulu-Natal's research agenda,
- Laying a foundation for international study programmes,
- International education opportunities, and

- MoU signing.

Global leaders, rated scientists and MUT's home-grown researchers and academics will join the conference virtually or in-person.



From left, former SA High Commissioner to California, Cyril Ndaba, Dr Joseph Bwapwa of Civil Engineering, Acting Vice-Chancellor and Principal, Professor Marcus Ramogale, and Professor Kaniki Tumba of Chemical Engineering



From left, Professor Marcus Ramogale, Dr Godson Gatsha, Deputy Vice-Chancellor: Academic at Botswana Open University (BOU), and Cyril Ndaba, former South African High Commissioner to California, US

PRINCE MANGOSUTHU BUTHELEZI OPENS HIS ARMS TO A VISIT BY AN MUT EMISSARY

The relationship between the Founder of MUT and the executive is one that embodies all MUT's values of accountability, integrity, respect, and excellence. At very short notice, the Founder's team was able to secure an urgent meeting on 22 July with the Founding father of MUT: Prince Mangosuthu Buthelezi. A few notable observations with the Founder at the request of Professor Marcus Ramogale:

- His response to the Vice Chancellor's letter was written to the emissary, "for accuracy", the Founder chuckled.
- He has a long and accurate memory which allows him to recall most things that have happened in his life.
- His ability to make everyone feel welcome and appropriate to be in his company.

The Founder was so excited to have the emissary that he even invited them to visit the Prince Mangosuthu Buthelezi Museum and Documentation Centre.

Mbali Mkhize, Senior Director of Marketing and Communications at MUT, described the centre as a magnificent place of "timeless treasures, windows to our past". Mkhize said a museum not only provides knowledge about the past, but it also provides information about the choices that individuals made.

"In the case of the University's Founder, Prince Mangosuthu Buthelezi, the museum traces his past and programmes he undertook to develop the marginalised. Soon, the University community should start thinking about an annual trip to pay homage to the leader, who established the first African technology institution in South Africa," said Mkhize.



HRH, Prince Mangosuthu Buthelezi (left), with MUT Registrar, Dr Phumi Masala

FOCUS CONFERENCE FIRMS ITS POSITION TOWARDS MAKING MUT A CONFERENCE HUB



From left, Professor Marcus Ramogale, Acting VC and Principal, left, and Dr Whitfield Green, CHE CEO, and Dr Manyane Makua, the Acting DVC: Teaching and Learning, at the conference

In 2012, during a meeting to develop the academic identity for MUT, Professor Marcus Ramogale in his capacity as Acting Deputy Vice Chancellor asked a question as to why MUT was not grasping opportunities to become leaders in convening conferences where various speakers could contribute towards a body of knowledge and strengthen MUT's teaching and learning, and research. Dr Makua, Senior Director, Teaching and Learning at the time, grasped the opportunity and has never looked back. A 'Focus' Conference, focusing on teaching and learning, soon emerged out of MUT. The rest as they say is history, suffice to say that the *Focus Conference* is the biggest and the only teaching and learning conference in the country.

This year, this nine-year old conference took this seed to germination, under the theme 'Re-inventing higher education: insights, trends, and lessons learnt from Covid-19'. The Focus conference was hosted from 17 to 19 August 2022 at Durban's Elangeni Hotel. This annual Focus Conference, which is the premier teaching and learning conference, homegrown at MUT's Teaching and Learning Development Centre (TLDC) has become the University's flagship project on teaching and learning. It is also an inspiration to the country's teaching and learning agenda, given that at least 60% of the delegates were external.

This year's conference featured prominent scholars in the world of teaching and learning, along with academic

leaders who experienced the impact of Covid-19 on teaching and learning first-hand. The conference brought thought leaders to contribute to a new body of knowledge that would advance teaching and learning under and post-Covid-19. 'Blended learning' may still be with all universities in the next year, this is according to experts in higher education, including Dr Whitty Green, CEO of the Council on Higher Education (CHE).

Global leaders in higher education, invited by Professor Ramogale and Dr Manyane Makua, Acting MUT Deputy Vice Chancellor: Teaching and Learning, included Dr Green, CEO of the Council on Higher Education (CHE), Professor Adam Habib, Director of the School of Oriental and African Studies at the University of London, Professor Tinyiko Maluleke, Vice Chancellor of Tshwane University of Technology and many more. Their presentations showed a greater need to prepare for the future, look at lessons learnt and to become more agile and adaptable because the pandemic and its lockdown actions may not be the last one. The pandemic has brought a huge shift in higher education. Issues of inequality, quality access, change management and adaptability should be a high priority for universities, reiterated speaker after speaker.



2022 FOCUS CONFERENCE

The Premier Teaching & Learning Conference

Theme:
Re-inventing higher education: insights,
trends and lessons learnt from COVID-19

17-19 AUGUST 2022



From left, Professor Monwabisi Ralarala, from the University of the Western Cape; Professor Marcus Ramogale, Acting VC and Principal at MUT; and Dr Manyane Makua, the Acting DVC: Teaching and Learning, at the conference

Things taken for granted in developed countries such as students owning laptops and having easy access to internet connectivity 24/7 at no cost, became highly defined under Covid-19 and created disparities not just within one institution but across numerous institutions nationally and internationally. Dr Green says "students found themselves all alone, with no laptops, with no lecturers, but with some family members who may not have any idea what the student was doing. It became clear that the well-intended step was not yielding any positive results. One of the results of this kind of disengagement from a system was that some students got frustrated and dropped out of the system."

"All these boil down to the issue of pedagogy", Dr Makua believes that the design of online material must

be bespoke for online and not treat pedagogies as one size fits all. This is a conversation he is passionate about and has gone on record at MUT's Senate advocating for online platforms to not be spaces where only lecture notes get posted. "There is a need to build capacity in learning design and there is a need for professional development in learning design". This would help fill the gaps associated with issues of inequality and quality.

Professor Ramogale, well known as an ardent reader, shared his insight from a book titled '*A world without work*', in which the writer shows how new technologies have impacted the world of work, bringing dislocation, "but overall people move on; with new jobs getting created and society benefiting despite anxieties when new technologies emerge", he said. While the student success rate under Covid-19 jumped from 78% to 83% the question of quality being compromised is prevalent but could also be attributed to the fact that new technologies are bringing new efficiencies.

The *Focus* conference speakers explored various in which ways the matters of equality and transformation and issues of adaptability, by both students and lecturers can be overcome.

<https://www.mut.ac.za/the-annual-focus-conference-shines-a-spotlight-on-the-state-of-education-in-the-country/>

EMPOWERED ADMINISTRATORS CONFERENCE GROWS ITS Foothold



NO GREATER TIME THAN NOW!

The Empowered Administrators Conference (EAC) which was held at Gateway Hotel in Durban, is in its 9th year and brought over 100 delegates, slightly less than the previous years because “Covid-19 has created a new competitor, and that competitor is digitalisation”, said Ms Mbali Mkhize, Senior Director, Marketing and Communications. “A lot of delegates had requested that the conference become hybrid, an unfortunate request because this conference is about an office lifestyle, a fundraiser for the University, a networking event and an opportunity to practice what you are learning on the spot”, said Ms Mkhize.

Despite the challenges brought about by the pandemic such as social anxiety (fear of meeting people), organisational financial challenges, and travel fear; the

conference grew its footprint in a new market. This year, the EAC welcomed delegates from different universities, State-owned-Enterprises, private sector, and the non-profit sector.

This year’s EAC theme was, “*No greater time than now*”, a theme meant to address agility and future-proofing the job of the office professional in the event of future lockdowns or pandemics.

Welcoming the conference delegates, Professor Ramogale, Acting Vice-Chancellor spoke about the power that office administrators have “which I do not think you realise and should be using optimally. You have power over many people because you have high level access to information than some of your colleagues or even your



Delegates that attended the EAC, and MUT staff

senior people within departments. This power should be a springboard for your success. To make an example, your future growth within organisations is based on what you know and how you use that information to help your office succeed and for your professional development. The fact that you have access to privileged information is power. Let people respect you for the information you know. Do not ever share confidential information. It is your power, your gateway to being respected for being trustworthy and having integrity.”

Conference speakers tackled many topics which may impede progress on efficiency and effectiveness of office professionals. These are some of the selected speakers:

BEING AN HONOURABLE REPRESENTATIVE OF YOUR ORGANISATION



Ms Toni Gumede, Brand South Africa

Addressing delegates on the first day of the conference, Ms Toni Gumede from Brand South Africa, reminded participants that they represented their organisations in all

that they do regardless of their positions. Gumede added that office administrators are required to know everything about their organisations as they are important sources of information and drivers of organisational efficiency.

“You are the stakeholder person, you are the communication person,” said Ms Gumede. “You need to know more about the organisation than the leadership of the organisation.”

She cautioned delegates about engaging in unethical behaviour such as inviting friends to listen to confidential virtual meetings. Ms Gumede added that it was important for office administrators to build professional relationships and collaborations. She said office administrators had to be abreast with what is happening in their organisations and it was their task to ensure that organisational databases are up-to-date and accessible.

GETTING A PROMOTION



Dr Thandeka Ellenson, CEO of the Moses Kotane Institute

One of the more popular sessions was presented by Dr Thandeka Ellenson, CEO of the Moses Kotane Institute. Dr Ellenson, who is a MUT alumna, reminded office administrators that they are an extension of their managers, and are required to have the necessary skills and emotional backbone that is required in their environment. Dr Ellenson, whose session was on empowering office professionals with advice on getting a promotion, took delegates through an exciting presentation on various career tracks that they could follow. She informed delegates that she also started her career as an administrator and took every opportunity that came her way. She singled out online learning as an opportunity that all should take advantage of and register for qualifications that would be beneficial to their growth.

PLANNING FOR THE UNKNOWN



Thando Radebe, Turn Around Project Manager, MUT

Another speaker, Thando Radebe, the Turn Around Project Manager at the University, advised delegates

to have a well-defined character that would make it easy for others to identify with. This will make the interaction between the office administrator and their stakeholders easier. Radebe also told the delegates that it was important for them to be able to have foresight and visualise what could happen in the future adding that it was important for the delegates to plan how they could deal with challenging situations like the return of Covid-19.

She advised delegates that it was important for them to understand their strengths and acknowledge their weaknesses when planning for various scenarios. "This is the time for you to find your strength zone. When you are outside your strength zone and comfort zone you must expect mediocre performance. The best for me is being outside my comfort zone in my strength zone. The difference is in knowing the difference," said Radebe.

LEADING WITHOUT THE TITLE AND ENGAGING STAKEHOLDERS



Mthokozisi Luthuli, Durban University of Technology

Mthokozisi Luthuli, a Lecturer from the Durban University of Technology's Department of Entrepreneurial Studies and Management, reminded delegates that they could influence their stakeholders even though they were in positions that may not have authority. Luthuli said that office administrators should positively influence their stakeholders. While Liile Lekena, a Director in the University's Directorate of Institutional Planning and Research (DIPR), reminded the office administrators that their efficiency is translated into their office's performance. She said a weak office administrator resulted in a weak manager's office. Lekena added that office administrators should be ambassadors of their organisations.

DEALING WITH WORKPLACE PREJUDICE AND BRINGING BACK OFFICE DECORUM



Senamile Masondo, HR Business Partner, MUT

Senamile Masondo, HR Business Partner from the Department of Human Resources and Development at MUT informed delegates about the importance of being aware of the dangers of prejudice. Masondo told delegates that they needed to check their own prejudices, reflect upon where they come from, and intervene when others are being subjected to workplace prejudice.

BEING AN EXPERT IN ADOPTING TECHNOLOGY



Sandile Mahlaba, Microsoft Provincial PS Executive

The delegates of the 2022 conference were also empowered by the University's members of the Department of Information Technology and Networks,

Danie Venter and Pritham Seethal. The ITN duo cautioned delegates that as they handle lots of personal information they needed to comply with the applicable government regulation so that they, and their organisations, did not get in trouble with the law.

One of the highlights of the conference was presented by MUT alumnus, Sandile Mahlaba, Microsoft Provincial PS Executive who took delegates through Microsoft 365 and Teams. The tutorial was given based on the anticipation that remote communication will continue even after Covid-19. Mahlaba said the tutorials would continue after the conference to give delegates further training. Mahlaba who is also an MUT alumnus dedicates time to the EAC as part of paying back to his alma mater.

INSIGHTS FROM THE DELEGATES



Lebo Sibisi, University of KwaZulu-Natal

On the second day of the conference, delegates were given a chance to respond to questions that sought to find out how they applied what they learnt in their real situations. One delegate said she had to take charge and devised new measures to ensure that her line manager's signature could not be copied or abused during the Covid-19 lockdowns.

Lebo Sibisi from the University of KwaZulu-Natal, said what the speakers told them was "really hitting home, Iyasibuyisa endaweni (it brings us back to where we need to be). Sibisi said what they were being told was renewing their knowledge after two years of Covid-19. She also expressed her gratitude to the conference for addressing topics that enriched office administrators.